his parents, Wilhelm and Karoline. ‘The East German leader was welcomed by a cheering crowd of about 1,000 people who lined the streets as his motorcade drove through the town,’ AP reported. ‘As he stepped out of the car and went into the green family house, some people waved East German flags but about twenty demonstrators carried signs protesting the shoot-to-kill orders and demanding freedom for East German political prisoners.’1

There were encounters with old friends and new admirers at a reception by the Lord Mayor in the Neunkirchen community hall, where – much to the surprise of Moscow and Erich Mielke – Honecker gave an emotional speech in which he spoke – in an off-the-cuff remark – of a day when Germans would no longer be divided by borders: ‘The day will come when borders no longer separate us, but unite us, just like the border between the German Democratic Republic and Poland.’ Though the remark probably revealed more about Honecker’s overwrought nerves than of his true convictions, West German tabloid Bild hit the newsstands with the quote: ‘Sensation! Erich Honecker: Our border can fall.’ Die Welt was more cautious, noting the SED leaders’ statement on the transitory nature of borders should be viewed carefully. ‘The border with Poland is not a dividing line between two different systems that Honecker compared to fire and water. Thus, we might suspect he wanted to suggest reunification under socialist premises.’2 Honecker’s ‘Neunkirchen remarks’ noted the Frankfurter Rundschau, ‘show that the man at the top of the GDR now is aware that shots at the Wall are the worst blemish of his state.’3 Speaking to reporters outside Neunkirchen community hall, Honecker said:

I was deeply impressed by the friendly reception accorded to me. The reunion with old acquaintances, friends and comrades in arms was a moving moment for me. I am grateful primarily to the mayor of Neunkirchen, Peter Neubert, and the people of the town for giving me this opportunity during my official visit to the FRG. I would like to say that my activities on the Saar have no more faded from by memory than has the time of the anti-fascist struggle in the Ruhr area, in Essen, Baden-Wuerttemberg and Berlin, which I waged with many staunch comrades in arms.4